protested overflights of the same Soviet ships: “I can tell you: in August there were 140 cases of such buzzing.”

Khrushchev wanted to distract Kennedy’s attention from Cuba and discourage him from invading the island. Once again, he was trying to use a carrot and a stick to achieve his goal. The carrot was the nuclear test-ban treaty. “Well, I can say quite definitely that we will not make you wait,” wrote Khrushchev in response to Kennedy’s proposal to make major progress on the treaty before the end of the year. The stick, as always, was Berlin. Khrushchev ended his long letter by promising to do nothing about Berlin before the elections and threatening drastic actions after that. “After the elections, apparently in the second half of November, it would be necessary in our opinion to continue the dialogue,” he wrote. It was more a threat than an invitation to dialogue.[15]

On the following day, Kennedy summoned two of his most experienced Russia hands, the former ambassador to Moscow Charles “Chip” Bohlen and the serving ambassador, Llewellyn Thompson. When asked why they thought Khrushchev had ordered the buildup in Cuba, both raised the ideological component of his decision: “[W]ithin the bloc, the Communist bloc, this is a good step for him.” Bohlen wanted Kennedy to issue a strong rebuke to Khrushchev in order to counter his assertions that the United States was too liberal and soft to fight over the issues at hand. “But the thing he’s interested in, which is the only thing you worry about, is a nuclear war,” Bohlen told the president, suggesting that Khrushchev was exploiting Kennedy’s concern about triggering a nuclear confrontation by pushing him on Berlin. He added: “And this is cockeyed, I think.”

Bohlen tried to decouple Berlin from Cuba in Kennedy’s mind. When the president suggested that an invasion of Cuba might lead to a Soviet seizure of Berlin, Bohlen admitted such a possibility but added: “[T]here are so many places, there are many instances where if we take certain kinds of forcible actions, the Russians can retaliate. I think we tend … to let the Berlin situation dominate our whole action.” Kennedy did not heed Bohlen’s advice and decided not to push back on Berlin. His response to Khrushchev’s letter, which he sent to Moscow on October 8, also did not touch on Cuba. The president decided to focus on the nuclear test-ban treaty alone, where Khrushchev seemed open to cooperation and possibly